

IN CONTEXT

The royal fireworks

In 1749, George II decreed that a firework display be mounted in London's Green Park to celebrate the end of the War of the Austrian Succession. Handel was commissioned to write music to accompany the display, the king specifying "no fiddles." A public rehearsal of the music in Vauxhall Pleasure Gardens attracted a paying crowd of 12,000 spectators, causing one of London's first traffic jams. Although the firework display itself was ruined by rain and by accidents that injured spectators and set fire to a pavilion, Handel's band resolutely delivered a rousing performance.



FIREWORKS IN GREEN PARK, 1749

A move to London

In 1710, Handel moved back to Germany, accepting the post of music director at the court of Hanover. This small, ambitious